

The Nitrogen Group

The metals, semi-metals, and non-metals in this group are known as the “pnictogens,” from an ancient Greek word that means “to choke.” This refers to the fact that someone breathing pure nitrogen would die from lack of oxygen—the name isn’t really relevant to the other members of the group, as none of them are gases at room temperature.

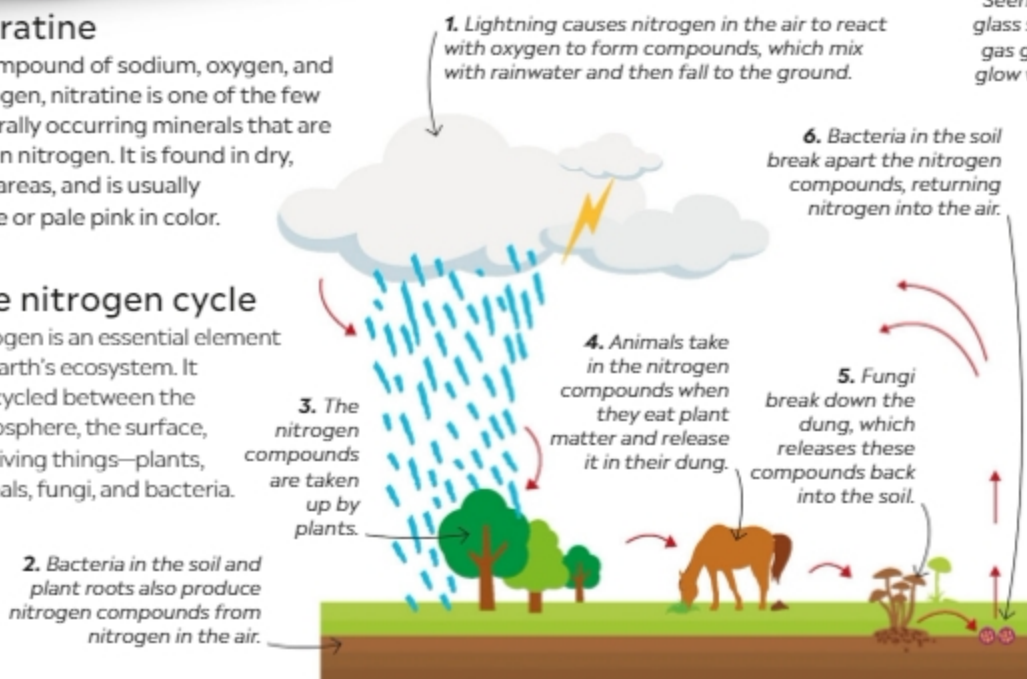


Nitratine

A compound of sodium, oxygen, and nitrogen, nitratine is one of the few naturally occurring minerals that are rich in nitrogen. It is found in dry, arid areas, and is usually white or pale pink in color.

The nitrogen cycle

Nitrogen is an essential element for Earth’s ecosystem. It is recycled between the atmosphere, the surface, and living things—plants, animals, fungi, and bacteria.



Nitrogen

7 **N** This element makes up 78 percent of Earth’s atmosphere. An invisible and odorless gas, nitrogen is continually transferred between the environment and living things in a cycle. In the soil, nitrogen plays a vital role in the growth of plants and fungi. Animals make use of nitrogen to build proteins, which are essential to life.



Seen here stored in a glass sphere, nitrogen gas gives off a purple glow when electrified.

